St. Egbert Organ Replacement Project

A proposal

BLUF / TL;DR

The organ at St. Egbert's is now more than 30 years old, making it vulnerable to part failures and ongoing repairs. Its sound sampling technology is outdated and uninspiring by modern standards, and the instrument itself is undersized for the church and the parish's music ministry program. The parish should begin proactively planning and raising money to replace it within the next few years, aiming to do so before it stops working to a degree that it is unfeasible to repair. Estimated project cost ranges from **$190,000** to **$264,000** (all inclusive) in 2026, with prices increasing roughly 16% each year—another reason to act sooner rather than later.

The recommended target organ for St. Egbert Church is a **Rodgers Infinity 367D** three-manual instrument at an estimated price of **$263,668** (cost breakdown below).

This proposal details why a new organ is needed, identifies and justifies the ideal replacement instrument, and provides an analysis of alternatives. Templated fundraising materials (an informational pamphlet and a fundraising pledge page) are appended for consideration as well.

Figure 1: The Rodgers Infinity 367D three-manual organ features "*a wide range of tonal genres, exceptional musical expressiveness, and unmatched versatility, providing everything that today's organists want and need to perform their best.*" (Rodgers Instruments)

Terminology

The following terminology are used throughout the proposal and defined here for convenience.

- **Console:** The part of the organ containing the manuals, pedalboard, and stop controls.
- **Division:** Groups of pipes in a pipe organ based on which keyboard they are played from. Some divisions are *enclosed*, meaning the pipes are located behind large sound-dampening shutters that allow the organist to dampen the sound, thereby decreasing the volume. Other divisions are *unenclosed*, meaning the pipes are fully exposed with no volume control.
  - **Great division:** The main division of the organ producing the strongest vibrant sound that most people associate with organs. Used primarily to support congregational singing.
  - **Swell division:** The second division on a two-manual organ named after the swell shades behind which its pipes are located to offer volume control. Useful for accompanying cantors or soloists.
  - **Choir division:** The third division on a three-manual organ, usually enclosed, but with a slightly stronger sound than the Swell division but not as strong as the Great. Useful for accompanying choirs or ensembles when foundational but not overpowering registrations are needed.
  - **Solo division:** The fourth division on a four-manual organ, usually characterized by stops that are voiced to stand alone and be heard above the rest of the organ. Useful for "soloing" the melody of a hymn so that it can be heard above the chords to help with unfamiliar or new melody lines.
  - **Pedal division:** The pipes played exclusively by the pedalboard.
- **Manual:** A keyboard consisting of 64 keys played with the hands.
- **Pedalboard:** A keyboard played with the feet controlling the lowest pitches of the organ.
- **Piston:** A programmable button used to set registrations for quick access during playing.
- **Rank:** A group of pipes, one per note, that have the same sound quality and timber but differ only in pitch from note to note. Each rank has its own unique sound, purpose, and use.
- **Registration:** Combination of stops used to produce desired sound while playing.
- **Shoe:** A pedal used to control a part of the organ:
  - **Swell** or **expression shoe:** Opens and closes the swell shades to vary the volume of enclosed divisions.
  - **Crescendo shoe:** Systematically adds stops to gradually and organically build up the volume of the instrument while being played.
- **Stop:** A subset of a rank of pipes based on their speaking pitch ranging from 32' pedal stops providing bass foundation to 2' (or smaller) manual stops that give bright high pitched sounds. Stop families include principals (full, strong, vibrant sound), flutes (softer sound that resembles flutes and wind instruments), strings, and reeds (nasally, "edgy" sounds that resemble reed instruments). Each stop has its own unique sound, purpose, and use.
- **Voicing:** The tuning of the sound quality (*e.g.*, bass, timbre) of every note of every stop on the organ to ensure everything is balanced properly.

Overview

The current organ at St. Egbert's is a two-manual Allen MDS-6 AK digital computer organ installed in September 1994 featuring sound technology from the late 1980s. Digital organs are budget organs for churches that are unable to afford full pipe organs, which can cost more than 10x as much as comparable digital organs. Pipe organs, when properly maintained, can outlive the building in which they are installed. Digital organs, on the other hand, are more like electronic appliances with an unavoidable shelf life. While there are digital organs that are more than 50 years old still in use, they are not the norm and have most certainly undergone expensive repairs over their lifetime. On average, churches should expect to replace a digital organ every 30-40 years or else budget yearly for ongoing repairs and be willing to spend what is needed to keep an old instrument in use.

The primary points of failure for digital organs are outdated electronics and technology. While Allen advertises indefinite support and repair of any organ they have ever sold, the reality is that, as instruments age, parts become increasingly difficult to obtain as old technology is replaced by newer state-of-the-art counterparts. Eventually, old parts are no longer made. At 32 years old, St. Egbert's is at risk of confronting this if the sound module (*i.e.*, the motherboard or "guts" of the organ) dies. If this were to happen, the sound board would need to be replaced with the same part off an equally old organ turned in for parts. For an estimated cost of around $15-20k (as of 2025), the church would end up replacing a 30+ year old sound module with another 30+ year old module, with no way of knowing how long this equally-old part itself would last.

The catalyst for this project has been a couple repairs needed in the last two years: a power supply in 2024 and an audio control switch in 2025. At risk of future failure are the amplifiers, speakers, sound module, and other controls, to name a few. As St. Egbert's enters this last quarter of the average digital organ's life, the parish would greatly benefit from proactively fundraising now so that it can comfortably replace it with something fitting for the church *before* the congregation finds itself desperately needing to quickly raise money for a dead instrument.

Replacing a digital organ presents exciting opportunities for a parish, not the least of which is a significant upgrade in audio technology. Computers have come a long way since 1994, and so too have digital computer organs. It is also an opportunity for the parish to reflect on its current music ministry program, envision its future, and select a suitable instrument capable of serving the parish's needs and fulfilling its musical dreams. For St. Egbert's this means choosing an instrument that is sufficiently flexible to lead the congregation, cantors, a choir, and instrumentalists, and is installed in such a way that the sound is balanced throughout the entire church.

Considerations for the existing organ

1. Parts failure due to age

At 32 years old (as of 2026), the current organ has reached the age at which most digital organs need to be replaced unless the church wants to spend money on keeping old technology running. In Advent 2024, the power supply for the organ failed spectacularly in the middle of a Sunday liturgy. When this happened, every note of every stop on the organ started sounding continuously at full volume, a consequence of improperly regulated power being received by the sound board. All that could be done was switch the organ off, rendering it unusable right before Christmas. The service call plus parts and labor cost a few thousand dollars. Fortunately, power supplies are not specialized parts, so a newer model was able to be installed.

Roughly a year later, an audio control switch failed, rendering half of the organ unusable. Because of the way old organs were designed, "half of the organ" meant that seemingly random stops across all divisions and within families of stops were affected. For example, in the Great division, the 8' principal stop became inoperable while the 4' principal stop still worked, and the 8' flute stop in the Great division worked but the 4' flute did not. The situation was similar in the Swell and Pedal divisions as well. This made it impossible to properly register the instrument for hymn singing and other musical needs. This service call plus parts and labor was another $2000 or so.

To be fair, Allen commits to repairing any organ it has ever sold—and repairs, even cumulatively, do cost a fraction of the price of a new instrument. The two recent repairs together cost just under $10k. But this is because neither involved specialized parts: while the original power supply is no longer made, it could be replaced with a newer model because power supplies are universal, and the switch, while not used on new organs anymore, was used by Allen for a sufficiently long period of time that new ones can still be acquired. Challenges arise, however, when parts that are no longer made and are no longer able to be acquired need replacing. The most critical example of this is the sound module, the motherboard or "guts" of the organ, the "digital computer" component that creates the sounds. This part, while state-of-the-art at the time, is no longer made, and because technology advances so much in several decades, new models are not backwards compatible with old organs. And herein lies the critical caveat to Allen's commitment: there comes a time when the only way to make certain repairs to an old organ is to replace old technology with the same old technology—in other words, an equally-old used part pulled off a similarly aged organ scrapped for parts. Allen service technicians will do this, and the price will still be much less than a new organ. The Eastern North Carolina Allen service technician, for example, estimated the cost for replacing the current sound board, should it be needed, to be tens of thousands of dollars in 2026—but for another 30+ year old part that could itself fail at any time.

The parish should carefully consider this reality and think about it like maintaining an old car. With enough money and trips to a trusted mechanic, any car can remain on the road indefinitely. But it still remains an old car with old technology and missing features. Is it worthwhile? It should be noted that there are dozens of other switches in the current organ, and service calls to replace them one at a time as they fail will add up. The most expensive repair would be the sound module, as mentioned. Other parts at risk of failing include the speakers (*i.e.* dried out and blown speaker cones), amplifiers (one for each of the two channels), the digital transposer, mechanical stop rails, and the expression shoe, to name a few.

2. Outdated audio technology

As the name implies, digital computer organs use onboard computers to replicate organ stops. Computers – and all digital technology – have come a long way in 30+ years. Built and installed in 1994, the current organ uses technology from the late 1980s and early 1990s. Each stop is digitally synthesized, meaning the sound is digitally imitated to the best of the ability of the technology at the time. While state-of-the-art in 1994, by modern standards, the sound generated by this organ is underwhelming, unconvincing, and uninspiring. Nowadays, the best pipe organs around the world are carefully and professionally recorded using top-of-the-line recording equipment. These recordings are essentially played back when keys are played on modern organs, making the sound of properly installed and properly voiced new digital instruments indistinguishable from real pipe organs.

Figure 2: Televisions have come a long way since the 1980-90s.

Figure 3: So have computers. And organs.

Interestingly, the majority of churches that replace old digital organs with new modern instruments experience notable increases in congregational singing and participation in music. The reason can likely be attributed to the same reason the Catholic church holds the pipe organ in the highest esteem above all other instruments: its unique ability to imitate the human voice. Both organs and the human voice are wind instruments whereby sound is created by moving air through a pipe. It turns out that the human ear is keenly sensitive to the authenticity of such sound. The authenticity of modern audio sampling and reproduction enhances our experience of the music it produces and inspires us to sing. Unfortunately, most parishes do not know what they are missing until or unless they invest in the upgrade to modern, stunningly authentic sound quality.

3. Organ is too small for liturgical and music ministry needs

The current organ is one of the smallest church organs Allen made at the time. The fact that it has an internal speaker in the console suggests that this model was intended for small churches, chapels, and practice studios rather than medium to large churches like St. Egbert's. It should be noted that the size of the organ does not refer to the volume of the instrument, but rather to the number of manuals, stops, and other features that provide flexibilities and capabilities to the organist.

The stop selection on the current organ is disappointingly lacking in a few areas. First, there is no 8' principal stop in the Swell division. Stops at the 8' pitch are the most import for singing, as this is the most natural octave for the human voice, and principal stops, as the name implies, are the most important stops on the organ. Principal stops produce the characteristic "bright" sound that most people think of when they think of an organ. Principal chorus are used very heavily in liturgical worship as the primary means of supporting congregational hymn singing. The absence of an 8' principal stop in the Swell division results in a hollow sound that lacks adequate foundation.

To make matters worse, the 4' principal (Spitzprinzipal 4') is described by Allen as "a hybrid stop which is predominately principal but with a string-like edge," but regrettably it sounds like neither a principal nor a string stop. In fact, it is arguably the worst sounding stop on the organ, which leaves the Swell division with no principal chorus whatsoever.

The organ also lacks reed stops, nasally "edgy" stops that resemble read instruments such as oboes or clarinets. Reeds can be used in any number of ways, but two common ways are to "solo" out a melody line, meaning the melody sounds louder and crisper over the rest of the chords. This makes the melody easier to hear, follow, and sing. This is particularly useful for teaching new songs or bringing a group of singers (choir or congregation) back together if they start fumbling with the melody or tempo in the middle of a song. The only reed stop on this organ is a Trompette 8' stop in the Swell division. While this can be used as a solo stop for processional, recessional, and sometimes offertory hymns, a trumpet stop playing at communion, for example, is much less liturgically appropriate. A second way reed stops are used is to add a subtle crisp nasally edge to a principal or flute chorus, the former of which usually has a bright "ringy" sound and the latter a soft gentler sound. This can help the human ear hear the pitches being played and is often used in the first verse of a hymn to get people comfortable singing the melody. This technique requires a softer reed stop that is not overpowering. The Trompette 8' does not serve this purpose at all.

Having multiple manuals makes it easy to quickly change the sound or volume of the organ in the middle of a piece. This is especially important for liturgical organists in the Catholic church. For example, responsorial psalms are often played using at least two manuals, one for the soft verse accompanying the cantor only, and another for stronger sound that brings in the congregational response. Additional manuals are handy when there are more musicians to support. For example, playing alongside other instruments (brass, reed, woodwind) requires a different registration than accompanying just a choir or a choir plus congregation in order to not drown out the instruments. The current organ offers no good stop combinations for these purposes. The principal chorus completely overpowers instruments on one hand while the flute chorus inadequately supports singing on the other hand. Given the level of appreciation of music within St. Egbert's parish, the robust congregational singing during Mass, the involvement of numerous instrumentalists, choir members, and cantors, all with different musical abilities, the parish would benefit greatly from a larger instrument with at least three manuals and twice as many stops.

Organ size also means number of audio channels. The current organ has only two channels, with all of the sound being delivered through two large speakers placed side-by-side on the side wall of the church. This is hardly ideal. First, this installation requires the organ to be much louder in volume to fill the church. It is overbearing to choir members and instrumentalists in the music area while sounding fine to congregants across the room. Second, having only two speaker cabinets compromises audio quality by "cramming" more sound through fewer speakers. Consider the difference in experience between a surround sound system and having one or two speakers side-by-side on one side of a room. More speakers does mean more volume: rather, it means a better distribution of sound, making it easier to hear and enjoy with less volume and less distortion.

> For what it's worth…
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> The installer of the current organ seems to have attempted to compensate for its small size with increased volume, a classic example of a poor installation. A larger organ does not mean louder; rather, it means having the right stops distributed across enough speakers to fill the room evenly with sound.

4. Missing functionality or unconventional behavior

Related to the size the of the organ, the organ lacks a number of common features and functionality that assist the organist, enhance the user experience, and make the instrument behave as expected. Some of the more notable deficiencies:

- **No second expression shoe:** The *expression shoe* or *swell shoe* on an organ is one way to change the volume of the organ. On a pipe organ, the pipes of *enclosed divisions* (such as the Swell division) are located behind (*i.e.*, enclosed by) large vertical shutters called swell shutters that open and close to dampen the sound. Three manual organs have two enclosed divisions, each with its own swell shoe, giving the organist much more flexibility. The current organ has one expression shoe that puts the Swell division under expression, which is expected behavior. It also has the option to put the Great division under expression, which would never be true on a pipe organ. The intent of this was to allow the organist to fake having a third division – a Choir division – under expression. The problem with this, however, is that in this mode, *the volume of the entire organ is modified by the single she.* This is not the way pipe organs behave and is not really a "feature" but rather an annoying attempt to make up for the absence of an important functionality.
- **No divisional pistons:** *Pistons* are preset buttons that allow the organist to store different registrations, or stop combinations, for easy access. The current organ has seven "general pistons" that control the entire organ. Many organs also have "divisional pistons" that control only one division, which can be very handy for targeted registration changes.
- **No MIDI:** Modern digital organs come equipped internal MIDI modules containing hundreds of additional sounds to supplement the organ stops. These sounds include additional organ stops and all sorts of instrument sounds, offering an enormous range of musical possibilities, especially for small churches unable to afford to hire instrumentalists. While the current organ is MIDI-ready, this option was never purchased.
- **No lighted music stand:** Most organs come with lighted music stands that eliminate the need for a bulky reading lamp. Unfortunately, the current organ does not have this, which is particularly annoying because the back corner of the church where the organ and musicians are located is notoriously dimly lit.
- **Unnatural transposer switch orientation:** The transposer switch raises or lowers the pitch of the organ to allow the instrument to sound in a different key than what is being played. On this organ, switching the transposer to the left *raises* the pitch, while switching it to the right *lowers* the pitch. This is completely unnatural, as pitch increases from left to right on all keyboard instruments. While merely an inconvenience, it requires the organist to be particularly careful when using the transposer to make sure it is engaged as intended.

5. Console age

The organ console itself is generally in good condition for its age, but it is worth noting that the wooden roll top cover is warped from years of humidity. It does open and close, but not well. Closing the organ, which protects it from dust, abuse, or vandalism, risks the cover binding and becoming stuck closed. The solution to this is to open the top service lid of the console and guide the cover back. The piston buttons have also started sticking, a common issue for these memory capture units when they age.

Proposed Solution

What

The ideal organ for St. Egbert's is a Rodger's Infinity 367D. The estimated cost breakdown for 2026, which includes a 10-year warranty, is as follows:

Table 1: Cost estimate of a Rodgers Infinity 367D organ installation based on 16% increase from 2025 prices, which represents the 2024-2025 price increase. Prices can be locked in for a period of time (usually up to one year) with the signing of a contract and initial deposit.

LINE ITEM	COST
Rodgers Infinity 367D organ (see note)	$220,017
Rolling platform	$4,000
Tax (if applicable)	$15,681
Buffer for parish expenses (10%)	$23,970
Total	**$263,668**

> **!** Important
>
> The cost of the organ includes installation and voicing but not any facilities work that may be needed to receive the organ. Examples might include wall-mounted speaker shelves or speaker wire conduit. A buffer equating to 10% of the project cost is included to cover these expenses.

Why

This three manual organ is well sized for St. Egbert church and is loaded with features and flexibilities that can completely transform the parish's music program with stunning tonal quality, remarkable versatility, and exceptional user experience. Some of its most notable features include:

- 67 stops (current organ has 28)
- 563 organ voices, 61 orchestral voices, and much more
- Mechanical (moving) drawknobs that give the organ an authentic behavior and visually stunning appearance
- 37 pistons, including general and divisional pistons, and 99 memory banks (current organ has 7 general pistons only and 2 memory banks)
- Two expression shoes and a crescendo shoe (current organ has one expression shoe and no crescendo shoe)
- Hymn player with 350 built-in hymns, plus the ability to record and play back anything
- Up to 22 audio channels (current organ has 2)
- Lighted and adjustable music stand with iPad support and automatic page-turn technology

The stop list is extremely versatile, with full principal, flute, and reed choruses in every division, plus a floating solo division that can be assigned to any manual. This makes the instrument very capable for accompanying congregational singing with a robust principal chorus in the Great division, cantors with soft yet articulate flutes in the Swell division, choir with supportive but softer principal chorus in the Choir division, and instruments with softer principal choruses on Choir or Swell division. The floating Solo division can be used on a moment's notice to help a struggling choir or congregation by articulating the melody line from any manual. Its four organ palettes (American Eclectic, English Cathedral, French Romantic, and German Baroque) offers immense flexibility and an infinite number of possible registrations, and the large orchestral library allows the organist to play dozens of other instruments as well, either by themselves or along with the organ.

The Infinity supports up to 22 channels of audio. The current proposal from Rodgers includes 14 channels for St. Egbert's: 10 would be used for the main organ, with speakers installed either in the rear of the church on either side of the stained glass window or (less likely) in the front on either side of the sanctuary. Unlike the current installation, which has only two channels, both of which are installed on one side of the church, this installation will allow the organ sound to be distributed evenly throughout the church without needing to overpower the speakers with excessive volume. In addition to these 10 channels, the proposal calls for a 4-channel antiphonal organ to be installed in the choir area. This will likely play only the Choir and Solo divisions to help the choir and instruments hear the organ in real time (without sound delays caused by the main organ speaking from the middle of the church). Importantly, the antiphonal organ will be voiced at a much lower volume than the main organ, providing only what is needed for musician support, not for the entire congregation. This setup resembles how a pipe organ would be installed in the church and will constitute a remarkable improvement over the current situation.

This organ also contains a built-in hymn player and recorder module. This allows a non-organist to play more than 300 pre-recorded hymns with the push of a button or from an app, and the recorder module allows the organist to record and play back additional music, such as Mass parts. This would be handy in the absence of an organist and other substitute, especially considering how difficult it has been to recruit substitute musicians at St. Egbert's.

Most importantly, the sound sampling technology provides stunningly accurate pipe organ sound, making modern digital organs indistinguishable from "the real deal." Even non-organists and non-musicians can tell the difference. One has to hear it to believe it, but the congregation can be assured it will not be disappointed! Some examples from YouTube:

- Trumpet Tune (Purcell): A popular wedding march that needs an articulate trumpet stop balanced by a principal chorus. The current organ lacks a trumpet solo stop like this, and the Trompette stop that it does have in the Swell division is completely overpowered by the principal chorus in the Great division, making it impossible to properly play this piece.
- Holy, Holy, Holy (NICEAN): A beloved traditional hymn familiar to the St. Egbert congregation
- O Come, All Ye Faithful: A rendition of the Willcocks arrangement of this beloved hymn
- Canon in D (Pachelbel): Another popular wedding piece, combined here with the well-known hymn tune "Seek Ye First" demonstrating the beautiful orchestral capabilities.
- The King of Love My Shepherd Is: A demonstration of the flute and principal choruses complementing each other and building organically throughout this familiar hymn in a way that is not possible on the current organ.

There are many more features and flexibilities that, together with its remarkable sound, make this state-of-the-art instrument a joy to play and not merely a liturgical organ, but a versatile concert instrument as well. The proposal also includes a rolling platform for the organ to enable it to be moved to the front of the church to offer, for example, fundraising concerts, if the parish opted to do this in the future. The Rodgers Infinity 367D is an investment in the future of the parish, as it truly has the ability to transform the music ministry and bring music at St. Egbert's to a new level.

When

While there is not yet an urgent need to replace the current organ, if the parish opts to proactively proceed with replacement before the instrument dies, it is encouraged to do so as soon as fiscally feasible, as prices have been increasing roughly 16% each year.

How

The Infinity 367D is the ideal instrument and its price should be considered the target amount to raise. While financing is available, this is discouraged in favor of taking the necessary time to raise the needed funds to avoid taking on debt. If, after some period of time, fundraising efforts plateau and fall short of the target, other options exist to be considered based on the amount raised.

The cost of a new organ often invokes sticker shock, but parishioners should be reminded that a comparable pipe organ would cost much more. Some fundraising strategies that have proven successful in other parishes include:

1. **Initial ask for money/big donations:** People generally like to donate to projects they can tangibly see or, in this case, hear. Many parishes have been known to end up with a handful of big donations that cover a bulk of the cost.
2. **Fundraising efforts:** Creative fundraising projects, like buying keys, pedals, or stops in memory of loved ones, can be effective for the average parishioner. A sample flyer and pledge sheet are appended as examples.
3. **Capital campaign:** Either a stand-alone long-term fundraising campaign or combined into a larger parish capital campaign. If the latter, it is recommended that parishioners be given the option to give specifically for the organ replacement project.

A slightly newer Rodgers digital organ of similar size but with considerably more features than the current organ recently sold for $2,600 on Facebook Marketplace. There is a market for used organs, either for small churches or home practice organs. The current organ has an internal speaker, making it entirely self-contained, which could make it attractive. If it is still working when the parish decides to replace it, trying to sell it could be an option. Otherwise, the dealer will take it, possibly with a slight "trade in" discount, like when trading in a used car for a new one.

Analysis of Alternatives

Rodgers options

The next model down from the Rodgers Infinity 367 is the Imagine 359. A smaller yet equally capable organ, the Imagine 359D offers 51 stops, 147 organ voices, and 45 orchestral voices. It contains the same highly authentic sound technology but lacks many features and additional flexibilities of the Infinity 367. Priced at about $190k, which includes the same 14-channel audio installation described above, this organ would still be a remarkable improvement and upgrade from the existing organ. The cost estimate breaks down as follows:

Table 2: Cost estimate of the Rodgers 359D based on 16% increase from 2025 prices, which represents the 2024-2025 price increase.

LINE ITEM	COST
Rodgers Imagine 359D organ	$157,122
Rolling platform	$4,000
Tax (if applicable)	$11,279
Buffer for parish expenses (10%)	$17,240
Total	**$189,641**

Priced in between the Infinity 367D and the Imagine 359D is the Infinity 367L ($257k), which is exactly the same as the 367D except it has lighted drawknobs instead of mechanical drawknobs. Mechanical drawknobs are more realistic than lighted, since pipe organs are mechanical instruments.

The recommendation is for the parish to target the Infinity 367D but fall back on the Infinity 367L or Imagine 359D if fundraising stalls.

Other brands

The primary competitor to Rodgers in the United States is Allen. There are several reasons a Rodgers organ is being recommended over Allen, some of which are:

1. **Bang for the buck:** On the surface, Allen and Rodgers organs appear very comparable: similar stop lists, modern features and technology offerings, similar prices. But under the hood, Rodgers offers much more for the same, if not less, money. The best example is how the two manufacturers handle voice palettes. Both Allen and Rodgers offers multiple (usually 2-4) different voice palettes that change the voicing of the organ's stops. Rodgers, for example, offers four voice palettes: an American Eclectic organ, an English Cathedral organ, a French Romantic organ, and a German Baroque organ. On Rodgers organs, every stop can be changed individually to any of these four palettes, allowing tremendous flexibility and endless possibilities for registration. On Allen organs, however, the entire organ must be changed over. This one feature alone makes Rodgers immensely more versatile instruments.

2. **Sound quality:** Both manufacturers have loyalists who insist their favorite organ brand sounds more authentic than the other. In some ways, this is a subjective personal preference. Truth be told, as technology advanced over the decades, both manufacturers have gone back and forth with having the edge up on sound quality. In the latest generation of sound technology, Rodgers organs tend to sound much more authentic, while Allen organs continue to possess a characteristic "Allen" sound quality. While some organists prefer this unique sound, the counter-argument is that the goal of a digital organ is for the sound to be indistinguishable from that of a pipe organ. When a digital organ manufacturer has its own unique and recognizable sound, it doesn't sound like a pipe organ; it sounds like the specific brand of digital organs that it is.

3. **Installation:** While Allen organs have a well-deserved reputation for build quality, the company has a much worse reputation when it comes to installation and voicing. Proper installation and voicing are absolutely crucial for an organ to sound its best. Far too many churches have Allen organs that appear to be haphazardly dropped into place with little evidence of planning or consultation from trained organists. The current organ at St. Egbert's is an example of this. As mentioned, the organ speaks from only two speakers positioned side by side (a characteristic Allen installation) hanging on a side wall practically in a corner of the church. No pipe organ would ever be installed this way, so why should a digital organ? Like with installing a pipe organ, a digital organ installation should be well-thought out and executed. This includes determining the right size instrument for the room. When asked if he wanted to see a church to suggest an adequate instrument, an Allen sales rep said on the phone, "I don't need to see the room. We'll sell you whatever you want and make it work." That revealed a lot about why so many Allen organs around the country are so poorly installed. Rodgers reps, on the other hand, visited the church and made recommendations for instruments and installation methods, with emphasis placed on considering how a pipe organ would be configured in the church.

4. **Voicing:** Voicing is when every the sound note of every stop is custom-adjusted and fine-tuned for the room in which the organ is installed. This is a very important part of an organ installation, as it is what makes the instrument sound its best. Allen organs, if they're voiced at all, are often voiced by service technicians rather than organists. Rodgers uses organists to voice their instruments, a detail that makes a big difference.

Another lesser-known manufacture in the United States is Johannus, but these tend to be budget digital organs, which themselves are already budget organs. Johannus organs are ideal for private homes or practice studios, but they do not have much in the way of mid-size or large organs, so they are rarely found in churches. Their only three-manual instrument is very stripped down compared to either a Rodgers or an Allen and, aesthetically, leaves a lot to be desired. They also do not (yet) have the same reputation and track record as both Rodgers and Allen. Thus, Johannus has not been considered for St. Egbert's.

Virtual organ

Virtual organs are an emerging technology, the latest in the digital organ market. Virtual organs use regular computers – a desktop or laptop – and software to generate high-quality sound. There are several software options: Hauptwerk, the most common, started off free but is now subscription based, requiring new versions be purchased as they are released. GrandOrgue is a free open-source alternative, but it lacks documentation and there's no guarantee that it will stay free. Organova is a new web-based version, allowing the user to play organ samples directly from the cloud instead of through locally installed software. All of these options offer a wide variety of organ samples from all around the world, and their sounds are as authentic as a modern digital organ.

Virtual organs consist of custom consoles that either contain functional drawknobs or tabs, which are programmed to be controlled by the software, or touch screen monitors that the organist uses to engage or disengage stops. They are designed such that the computer plugs directly into them and the software can be configured to be controlled by all of the stops, tabs, pistons, and shoes on the console.

While these organs cost a fraction of the price of a digital organ, they are are still rarely installed in churches. There are several critical limitations and concerns. First is user experience. A computer-savvy organist will likely have little trouble adjusting to using a touch screen monitor to control the instrument, but a classically trained organist will undoubtedly cringe at the idea and find herself out of her element at such an instrument. It may, therefore, be difficult to find someone to play it in the future. For this reason, only mechanical virtual organ consoles should be considered for a church. Second, they lack the same level of support that one would get from a major manufacturer like Rodgers or Allen. Consoles, speakers, amplifiers, wires, computer, and software must be purchased separately and installed by the church. While not impossible to accomplish, assuming the right subject matter expertise is available in-house, this piecemeal setup introduces many potential points of failure and incompatibility. Third, software running on a computer is inevitably prone to software and hardware issues – crashes, operating system and software updates, computer slowing down over time. A digital organ powers up immediately when turned on, but a virtual organ needs to boot an operating system and load the software. This is not a problem for casual settings like practicing at home, but it raises concerns in a liturgical setting where dependability is paramount. Overall, while promising, this technology is considered to not yet be mature enough for installation in a church like St. Egbert's.

Pipe organ

Pipe organs are laudable investments: nothing is more authentic than the "real deal," and properly maintained, they will outlive their building. Pipe organs generally cost at least 10x as much as a comparable digital organ, and require regular maintenance, including tuning twice a year.

It has been assumed that a full pipe organ is out of reachable budget for St. Egbert's. If the parish wishes to go down this route, new proposals will need to be sought. It is worth noting that pipe organs are always custom-built according to desired specifications and room considerations. Because of this, a pipe organ that is plenty adequate for the parish needs yet also smaller than the Rodgers Infinity 367D could easily be designed, so a $2.6M price estimate could be unnecessarily high.

Summary

The Rodgers Infinity 367D organ is a remarkably impressive instrument that would be a tremendous upgrade from the current organ at St. Egbert's. With three manuals, 67 stops, more than 500 organ voices, and 14 audio channels divided between a 10-channel main organ and a 4-channel antiphonal organ, this organ is plenty adequate for the size of the church and the needs of the existing music ministry. With the current organ beginning to show signs of its 32 years of service, the parish is encouraged to proactively begin raising funds now so that it can replace the instrument before it dies completely. While the Infinity's price tag of $264k will require significant fundraising, it will constitute a dedicated investment in the future of the parish: its stunning fidelity to the sounds of pipe organs combined with endless possibilities of stop combinations and orchestral integrations will undoubtedly raise the parish's music program to a new level for decades to come.
